

The Poltergeist of Page 13

Allen Girls Adventures

Allen Girls Adventures · Library Labyrinth Edition

Chapter 1: Something Flips at Midnight

The Labyrinth Library stayed open until ten o'clock on Friday nights, which Maya Allen considered one of the greatest facts in the universe. The second greatest fact was that her best friends Alana and Natalia had both gotten permission to sleep over in the library's cozy reading loft — a privilege reserved for the Archivist Society, of which the three of them were very proud junior members.

"This is the best night of my life," Alana announced, spreading her sleeping bag between two enormous bookshelves. She was already wearing her star-covered pajamas and had her hair in two puffy braids. "Books. Snacks. No parents asking if I've brushed my teeth."

"You should still brush your teeth," Natalia said sensibly, but she was grinning.

SPARK floated down from the rafters, her holographic feathers cycling through soft amber and lavender. She was a phoenix AI — small enough to perch on a shelf, bright enough to light a whole room if she concentrated. "Sleep schedule logged," she said. "Snack inventory: one bag of cheddar crackers, two granola bars, one suspicious gummy situation Alana refuses to label."

"They're mystery flavor," Alana said with dignity.

Maya was already browsing the shelves, fingertips trailing the spines of novels she hadn't read yet. She loved the library at night. It smelled different — dustier, somehow warmer, as if the books breathed a little easier when most of the people had gone home.

Then, at exactly midnight — and Maya knew because SPARK's chest clock chimed softly — she heard it.

Flip.

She spun around. A thick green book on the shelf across the room had opened itself. The pages riffled through the air as though an invisible hand were searching for something specific. Then they stopped.

"Did you see that?" Maya whispered.

"I see everything," SPARK said, sounding unusually cautious. "That book opened to page thirteen."

Alana sat up in her sleeping bag. "Did a ghost just do that?"

Another book flipped open across the room. Then another. Each one landed on the same page.

Page 13.

"Okay," Natalia said, very calmly pulling her knees to her chest, "that's either a very organized ghost or a very dramatic coincidence."

A third book sailed off the shelf entirely and landed open at their feet. Page 13 stared up at them in the lamplight.

"Not a coincidence," Maya decided. She grabbed her notebook. Whatever was haunting page 13, she was going to figure it out.

Chapter 2: The History of Bad Luck

By morning — after a fairly sleepless night involving six more spontaneously opening books, one flying encyclopedia, and Alana knocking over an entire display of bookmarks in fright — Maya had filled four pages of her notebook with observations.

"Summary so far," she said, spreading the notebook on the reading table while SPARK projected a glowing timeline above it. "Every book that opened last night was different. Different authors, different subjects, different sections of the library. But every single one opened to page thirteen."

"Classic haunting behavior," Alana said, though she'd only learned what "haunting behavior" was approximately eight hours ago. She was eating a granola bar with great seriousness, as if it helped her think.

"I looked through every book," Natalia said. She'd been up since six reading. This was not unusual for Natalia. "Page thirteen in each one — the text is completely normal. Nothing weird written there. No secret messages, no scary warnings."

"Just an ordinary page," SPARK confirmed. She landed on the edge of the table and folded her wings. "Which means whatever is doing this wants the page noticed, not feared."

Maya chewed on her pencil. "What's special about the number thirteen?"

"Historically," SPARK began, and her feathers brightened the way they always did when she was about to give a lot of information, "thirteen has been considered unlucky in many Western cultures for centuries. Some hotels skip from floor twelve to fourteen. Some streets skip house number thirteen entirely. In publishing, some older books used to skip printing page thirteen altogether — they'd number it as twelve-a, or simply leave it blank."

Alana's eyes went wide. "So people literally leave page thirteen out?"

"Frequently. Or they treat it as less important. Readers often flip past it quickly because of the association with bad luck. In some surveys, page thirteen is statistically one of the least-read pages in any given novel."

There was a long silence.

"That's actually really sad," Natalia said quietly.

Maya was already writing. She underlined the word lonely twice in her notebook, though she didn't entirely know why yet.

"SPARK," she said, "how many books in this library have a page thirteen?"

SPARK's eyes flickered as she calculated. "Approximately four thousand, two hundred and sixteen."

Alana dropped her granola bar. "We're going to be here a while."

Chapter 3: Meet the Poltergeist

They found it at half past noon, hiding behind a shelf of atlases.

It did not look like what any of them had expected. Maya had expected something wispy and dramatic. Alana had expected something with glowing red eyes. Natalia had expected something that could be explained by physics.

What they found was a small, round, translucent creature about the size of a deflated basketball, with enormous blinking eyes, tiny stubby arms that ended in little page-shaped hands, and a permanent expression of someone who had just been startled by a loud noise and hadn't recovered yet.

It was hovering three inches off the ground, clutching a copy of an atlas of bird migration, open to page thirteen.

"Oh," it said, in a voice like rustling paper. "You found me."

"We found you," Maya confirmed. She kept her voice very calm, which took considerable effort.

"I wasn't hiding well," the creature admitted. "I knocked over four things on the way here. I'm not very good at being spooky."

"You were pretty spooky last night," Alana said, then immediately looked like she regretted admitting that.

The creature's enormous eyes blinked. It seemed both mortified and pleased. "Really? I practiced. I've been practicing for weeks. Usually when I flip the pages it just looks like a draft from the ventilation system." It drooped slightly. "The flying encyclopedia was an accident. I overestimated."

SPARK landed on a nearby shelf and tilted her head. "You're a poltergeist."

"A small one," the creature said, with some dignity. "Grade two. We're mostly assigned to libraries and archival spaces." It clutched the atlas tighter. "My name is Thirteen."

"Your name is Thirteen," Natalia repeated.

"It seemed appropriate." The poltergeist's eyes went very large and slightly watery. "I am the guardian of every page thirteen in this library. All four thousand, two hundred and—"

"We know the number," Maya said gently.

"Nobody reads us," Thirteen said. Its little page-hands trembled. "They flip right past. They see the number and they flinch and they go on to fourteen as if we're not even there. Do you know what it's like to have important information and nobody ever reaches you?"

There was a long, sincere pause in which all three girls felt genuinely terrible about the number thirteen.

"We're listening now," Maya said. "Tell us everything."

Chapter 4: What Lives on Page Thirteen

Thirteen led them through the library with the energy of someone who had been waiting a very long time to give a tour.

The poltergeist moved in a way that was difficult to describe — it didn't walk so much as drift-and-bump, occasionally ricocheting gently off shelves and apologizing to them. Its tiny page-hands gestured dramatically at every stop.

"This one," Thirteen said, pulling a slim red novel from the shelf and flipping it open, "has a page thirteen describing the treasure map. The whole book is about the treasure. The map is on page thirteen. Readers who skip it spend the entire story confused." It shook its round head. "Entirely preventable."

"That's actually a problem," Natalia agreed, leaning in to read. She immediately became absorbed in the map for thirty seconds before catching herself.

"This one," Thirteen continued, moving to the science section, "is a book about weather patterns. Page thirteen explains what causes thunder. The chapter on page fourteen says 'as explained on the previous page' fourteen times. Fourteen times."

"That must be embarrassing for page fourteen," Alana said.

Thirteen pointed at her. "Yes! Yes, exactly! Page fourteen is carrying enormous context debt!" It swirled with a sound like shuffled cards. "And this one — this one is my favorite."

It floated to a middle shelf and drew out a thin, old book with a cloth cover. The title read: Collected Stories for Curious Children, Vol. III. It opened with great ceremony to page thirteen.

The page held a short story called "The Girl Who Asked Why."

Maya read the first paragraph. Then the second. She read the whole page standing there, notebook forgotten in her hand.

It was the best paragraph she'd read in weeks — a girl discovering that the people around her didn't know the answers to most things and that this was fine, actually, because it meant there was still exploring to do. It was funny and sweet and a little bit true in the way that only old books managed to be.

"Why isn't this famous?" she asked.

"Because it's on page thirteen," Thirteen said, and for a moment the little poltergeist just sounded tired rather than dramatic.

SPARK was quiet for a moment. Then she said, "I believe I understand the nature of the haunting now."

"So do I," Maya said. She was already forming a plan. "And I think I know how to fix it."

Chapter 5: The Midnight Reading Club

The plan, as Maya explained it, was simple in concept and utterly chaotic in practice.

"Every book with a page thirteen," she said, spreading a map of the library across the reading table, "needs to have its page thirteen read aloud. Thirteen said that's what breaks the cycle — someone reads it out loud, with friends present. The page gets witnessed."

"How many books is that again?" Alana asked.

"Four thousand, two hundred and sixteen," SPARK said.

Alana put her head on the table.

"We don't have to do all of them," Maya said quickly. "Thirteen said there are about forty that are causing the actual disturbance — the ones that have the most important information on page thirteen that nobody has read in over a decade. If we read those ones aloud before the next midnight, the poltergeist activity will calm down."

"Forty books," Natalia said. "That's manageable. We have—" she checked the clock "—eleven hours."

"Comfortable," Alana said, lifting her head. "Totally comfortable."

It was not comfortable.

Thirteen turned out to be an extremely energetic guide once it realized they were actually trying to help. It zoomed through the shelves with growing confidence, occasionally misjudging turns and phasing halfway through a bookcase before reversing itself with an apologetic wave.

They set up a reading station in the center of the library: three beanbag chairs, SPARK hovering overhead as both a light source and a timer, and a steadily growing stack of books with page thirteen bookmarked.

Alana read first. She'd selected a book about deep-sea creatures, and page thirteen featured an illustration of an anglerfish alongside a description of its bioluminescent lure that she found so genuinely fascinating that she forgot she was supposed to be completing a task and just kept reading.

"Alana," Natalia said.

"It makes its own light," Alana said, not looking up. "It makes its own light, Natalia. It's dark everywhere and it just — it makes its own light."

"That is genuinely wonderful," SPARK agreed. "However, we have thirty-nine remaining."

Alana read the page aloud. When she finished, there was a soft chime — not from SPARK, but from somewhere

in the library itself, a small and satisfied sound, like a sigh.

Thirteen made a noise that might have been crying, but in a good way.

"One down," Maya said. "Keep going."

Chapter 6: Jump Scares and Gelatin

At book number fourteen, the library decided to make things interesting.

Maya was in the middle of reading aloud from a historical atlas — page thirteen contained a surprisingly important footnote about trade routes that explained everything about the following two hundred pages — when every light in the library went out simultaneously.

In the darkness: silence.

Then, from directly behind Alana: "BOO."

Alana launched herself approximately two feet into the air, knocked the book out of Maya's hands, and landed in the beanbag chair with so much force it skidded backward into a shelf. Three books fell off the shelf. One landed on Alana's head.

SPARK flared immediately, flooding the room with warm amber light.

Standing behind the beanbag chair was Thirteen, its enormous eyes wide and hopeful.

"Did that work?" the poltergeist asked. "Was that spooky? I've been trying to improve my technique."

"THIRTEEN," Alana said, holding her chest.

"I was practicing." It drifted backwards slightly. "I thought since you were helping me I could try to help you experience the haunting more authentically—"

"Nobody needs to experience anything authentically," Maya said, pressing her lips together very hard because she could feel a laugh trying to escape. "We are doing very well on our own, thank you."

"You have a jump-scare schedule?" Natalia asked, because Natalia always got to the practical questions fastest.

Thirteen brightened. It produced — from somewhere — a small handwritten list. The handwriting was extremely wobbly, which made sense given that its hands were page-shaped. "I made a list. I have seventeen planned. I worked on them all week."

"Seventeen," Alana repeated flatly.

"There's one involving a gelatin mold," Thirteen said, with considerable pride. "I'm not certain where I acquired

the gelatin."

"Absolutely not," Alana said.

"What if I only do three?" Thirteen asked. "The non-gelatin ones?"

There was a brief negotiation. The final agreement was: two jump scares, neither involving food products, both administered only when Maya signaled with three taps on the reading table. Thirteen accepted these terms with visible disappointment but also visible relief that they weren't leaving.

"Back to the atlas," Maya said, recovering the book. She cleared her throat and resumed reading, while Natalia kept one eye on Thirteen just in case.

The footnote about the trade routes turned out to be genuinely fascinating.

Chapter 7: The Page That Nobody Read

Book number twenty-three stopped them cold.

It was a thin paperback, unremarkable to look at — pale blue cover, slightly water-damaged spine, a story about a girl learning to sail. Natalia had pulled it from the shelf on Thirteen's instructions, and when Maya opened it to page thirteen, all three of them went quiet.

The page was blank.

Not blank as in empty — blank as in the text was so faded it had become almost invisible, worn away by age and damp until only the ghost of letters remained.

"This one," Thirteen said, its voice much smaller than usual, "is the oldest. It hasn't been read from in forty-seven years. I know because I keep track."

Maya tilted the book toward SPARK's light. She could make out words — just barely. A sentence. Two sentences. She squinted.

"I can read it," she said slowly. "Give me a minute."

She read it aloud haltingly, piecing together letters: a girl standing at the bow of a boat at dawn, the cold spray, the feeling that the whole ocean was just waiting to be crossed, and the thought — which the author had clearly considered very important — that the only thing standing between a person and everywhere else was the decision to start.

When she finished, her voice had gone a little rough.

The library made that small chiming sound again. But this time it was longer, and warmer, and from somewhere very far back in the stacks they heard the sound of many pages fluttering at once — not violently, the way they

had at midnight, but gently, like a collective exhale.

"Forty-seven years," Alana said softly.

Thirteen was definitely crying now — transparent tears drifting upward rather than down, because it was a poltergeist and gravity applied to it only loosely. "She wrote that in 1978. Her name was Claire. She was eleven when she wrote that sentence. And she brought the book here and nobody ever—" Thirteen stopped.

"We read it," Natalia said. "All three of us heard it."

"SPARK heard it too," SPARK added.

Thirteen made a noise somewhere between a hiccup and a chime. "Yes," it managed. "You did."

Maya put the bookmark in at page thirteen. Not to skip it — to mark it. To say: this one matters, come back to this.

"Seventeen more," she said. "Let's keep going."

Chapter 8: The Encyclopedia of Jump-Scare Attempts

It was at book thirty-one that Thirteen deployed Jump Scare Number One.

Maya had given the signal — three taps on the table, as agreed — partly because she'd been watching Alana grow tense over the last hour and thought a controlled scare would actually help, and partly because she was genuinely curious how Thirteen had planned it.

The poltergeist had clearly prepared.

The lights went out. There was a dramatic whistling sound from the ventilation system, which Thirteen had somehow convinced to cooperate. Then, from three different corners of the library simultaneously, books flung themselves off shelves and landed open to page thirteen. Then the lights came back on and Thirteen appeared directly in front of Alana's face making its absolute most terrifying expression, which involved bulging its eyes to twice their normal size and showing its small flat teeth.

"AAAH!" Alana said.

"AAAH!" Thirteen said, apparently also startling itself.

They both jumped backward. Thirteen clipped the edge of the reading table and sent two bookmarks flying. Alana knocked into Natalia, who caught her with the practiced calm of someone who had been catching Alana mid-startle for years.

Maya was laughing so hard she had to sit down.

"Did I do it?" Thirteen asked, spinning in a small anxious circle. "Was that the correct amount of terrifying?"

"That was beautiful," Maya wheezed.

"I practiced the eye thing in a mirror," Thirteen said, with tremendous dignity, though its eyes were still slightly larger than usual. "It took four days."

"In a mirror," Natalia repeated. "You can see yourself in mirrors?"

"Yes. Mirrors are very important to poltergeists." It paused. "Also windows. And the reflective side of certain cooking trays, which is how I was able to practice in the kitchen of the apartment above the library."

"There's an apartment above the library?" Alana said.

"Mr. Fenwick lives there. He has many cooking trays and he is an extremely sound sleeper." Thirteen's expression went slightly guilty. "I left everything tidy."

Alana, Maya, and Natalia exchanged a look that communicated several things simultaneously: that they would not be mentioning the cooking tray situation to any adults, that they were very glad Thirteen was on their side, and that they needed to finish the remaining nine books before midnight.

"Book thirty-two," Maya said, recovering. "Let's go."

Chapter 9: The Twist in the Tale

With nine books left, Natalia asked the question that had been sitting in the back of Maya's mind all day.

"Thirteen," she said, looking up from a book of poetry whose page thirteen contained what was genuinely the best stanza in the entire collection, "what happens if we don't finish? What happens at midnight if there are still pages that haven't been read?"

The poltergeist's eyes went wide — wider than usual, which was saying something. It drifted backward until it bumped gently into a shelf.

"Well," it said.

"Well," Maya echoed.

"The activity escalates," Thirteen admitted. "I've been very restrained this week. Forty books is actually the calm version."

"What's the non-calm version?" Alana asked.

Thirteen made a gesture that encompassed roughly the entire library. "Every book. All four thousand, two hundred and sixteen. All opening at once."

A silence.

"That would be," SPARK said carefully, "a significant atmospheric event."

"The librarian would hear it," Thirteen said. "She lives only three blocks away. She would come in at midnight to investigate and find—" it waved its page-hands, "—everything."

"She'd find the evidence of a poltergeist," Maya said.

"And then she would call people," Natalia said, the word people carrying a specific weight. The kind of people who dealt with paranormal disturbances in official capacities. The kind of people who might not be particularly kind about a small, round, not-very-spooky poltergeist who had only wanted someone to read to.

Thirteen shrank slightly. "I don't want to leave the library. It's the only home I've had."

Maya stood up. "Then we'd better hurry." She handed Alana and Natalia each two books. "Split up. Each of us takes a section. Read page thirteen aloud — it counts even if we're in different parts of the room, Thirteen confirmed that, right?"

"It counts if the reader means it," Thirteen said. "If you're genuinely listening to the words."

"We will mean it," Natalia said firmly, already moving toward the history section.

"We always mean it," Alana agreed.

SPARK split her light three ways, casting warm beams toward each corner of the library. Thirteen watched them go, its enormous eyes following each girl in turn, and made a sound very much like someone who had waited a long time to not be alone and was still getting used to how good it felt.

Chapter 10: All the Thirteens

The next forty minutes were unlike anything Maya had experienced in a library before, which was saying something given that this was her third year as a junior archivist.

She was stationed in the science wing, reading aloud page thirteens from books about geology, bird migration, the history of the number zero, and — unexpectedly — a very old cookbook whose page thirteen contained a recipe for honey cake that made her genuinely hungry.

Across the library she could hear Alana's voice rising and falling — Alana read dramatically, with different voices for different subjects, and Maya could make out at least two accents and what sounded like a brief impression of a formal announcer delivering the information about tectonic plates. Every so often there was a small chiming sound from somewhere in the stacks.

Natalia read quietly but clearly, each word precise. She was in the reference section — the densest, most serious part of the library — and Maya knew without seeing her that she was reading every page fully, not skimming,

taking in the information the way Natalia took in everything: completely.

Thirteen zoomed between all of them like a small excited satellite, occasionally gasping when a particularly important passage was reached, making the chiming sound itself when it was too overcome to wait for the library to do it.

Maya reached her final book: a thin atlas of rivers, slightly battered. She opened it to page thirteen.

It was a map of a river delta — dozens of channels branching out from a single source, spreading across the page in blue ink, each channel labeled with a name in a different language. At the bottom, in small text, the author had written: Every river starts the same way. It just goes different places after.

She read it aloud. Her voice echoed in the tall shelves.

The library rang — not a small chime this time, but a full, resonant sound, like a bell struck with great deliberateness, rolling through every aisle and corner, touching every book on every shelf.

Across the room, she heard Alana say: "I think that was the last one."

And Natalia: "I think you're right."

The clock on the wall read eleven fifty-three.

Seven minutes to midnight. They'd made it.

Chapter 11: What Page Thirteen Said

The chiming faded. The library settled into a stillness that felt different from the one before — looser, somehow, as if something that had been held tight for a long time had been let go.

Thirteen floated to the center of the reading room and stopped. Its enormous eyes moved from Maya to Alana to Natalia to SPARK and back again.

"It's done," it said. Its voice was different — less tremulous, less wound-up. Just quiet.

"How do you feel?" Alana asked.

"Like when you've been holding your breath for a very long time," Thirteen said, "and you finally don't have to anymore."

Maya sat cross-legged on the floor. Her notebook was in her lap, but she wasn't writing. "Can I ask you something? Why did you flip the pages so dramatically? You could have just — I don't know — left a note. Made a sign. Something less alarming than a midnight book storm."

Thirteen considered this with great seriousness. "I thought about a note. The problem is that notes are very easy to

ignore. But a book flying at someone in a dark library at midnight—"

"Is very hard to ignore," Alana confirmed, rubbing the back of her head.

"Exactly." Thirteen did something that might have been a shrug. "I also thought — if I was going to ask for help, I should make it memorable. Page thirteen is always forgotten because it seems ordinary. I needed to be the opposite of ordinary."

"You were," SPARK said, and she meant it as a compliment.

"What happens now?" Natalia asked. "Will the books keep opening?"

"No. Once the pages are witnessed — really read, really heard — they're not forgotten anymore. The people in this room know what's on every one of those forty page thirteens. The information exists in your memory now." Thirteen tilted its round head. "That's what I was trying to do all along. Not haunt. Just — transfer."

"You wanted to teach us," Maya said.

"I wanted someone to learn," Thirteen corrected gently. "There's a difference."

The clock read eleven fifty-eight.

Maya stood up. She crossed the room to the shelf where the old blue sailing book sat, and she took it down, and she turned to page thirteen, and she read Claire's sentence aloud one more time — the one about the ocean waiting to be crossed.

"For the record," she said.

Thirteen made the sound of someone finally, thoroughly, deeply okay.

Chapter 12: The Thirteenth Member

The clock struck midnight.

Nothing flew off a shelf. No books opened themselves dramatically. The Labyrinth Library stood in total orderly quiet, the way libraries were supposed to stand at midnight — full of stories that were exactly where you'd left them.

Thirteen drifted down until it was hovering just above the floor, round and slightly transparent in SPARK's amber light, looking smaller than it had when they'd found it behind the atlases.

"I suppose," it said, "you'll be going to sleep now."

"Eventually," Maya said. "We still have granola bars."

"And the mystery gummies," Alana added.

"And I have a lot of questions," Natalia said, pulling out her own notebook — thinner than Maya's, but dense with small handwriting. "I'd like to understand more about how poltergeist archiving actually works. Like, are you cataloging the pages? Do you have a system?"

Thirteen's eyes went very large. "You want to know about my system?"

"I want to know about all of it." Natalia sat down on a beanbag chair and opened her notebook to a fresh page. "Start from the beginning. How did you come to be assigned to this library specifically?"

The poltergeist made a sound somewhere between a chirp and a gasp. It floated closer, then stopped, then floated closer again, as if it kept expecting someone to tell it that this was a trick.

"Nobody has ever asked me that before," it said.

"Well," Natalia said, pen ready, "we're asking."

Thirteen sat — or the poltergeist equivalent of sat, hovering very close to the floor with its page-hands folded — and began to talk.

It talked about arriving in the library fourteen years ago, assigned as a grade-two archival poltergeist by an organization it described vaguely as "the administrative side of things." It talked about cataloging every page thirteen in the building and finding, one by one, what each one contained. It talked about the honey cake recipe and the trade route footnote and Claire's sentence about the ocean.

It talked for a long time. The girls listened the whole way through.

SPARK dimmed her light gradually until it was just a warm glow, the kind that made a library feel like the safest place in the world. Outside, the city moved through its midnight sounds. Inside, nobody slept.

Eventually Maya wrote two words in her notebook and underlined them: Thirteenth Member.

She showed it to Alana and Natalia. They both nodded.

"Thirteen," she said, "how do you feel about joining the Archivist Society?"

The poltergeist looked at the three girls, then at SPARK, then at the four thousand, two hundred and sixteen books surrounding them — each with a page thirteen that was no longer lonely.

"I would like that very much," it said.

And somewhere in the stacks, very softly, a single page turned.